

peers, our family members and more can all have a positive and negative impact on us—particularly when it comes to our finances. The question to ask is the same one we’ve been asking all the way through this book: Is my environment, including the people within that environment, serving me or sabotaging me? Now, I know some people will see this as callous and perhaps even unkind. But I’m not suggesting that as a result of your answer to that question you cut people out of your life. Instead, it’s about setting boundaries so you limit the impact they have on your physical, emotional and ultimately financial health.

Again, I want to return here to the work of Dr Brené Brown. In a discussion with Russel Brand in his *The Work of the People* podcast, Brené talked about research she’d undertaken where she and her team analysed data about what the most compassionate people they had interviewed had in common. They discovered there was one variable they all shared: they had ‘boundaries of steel’. Brené went on to explain that these very compassionate people, when interviewed repeatedly, said, ‘I’m compassionate because I do not subject myself to the abuse of other people’. From this research, Brené and her colleagues developed the idea of BIG: ‘What Boundaries need to be in place so that I can be in my Integrity and be Generous toward you?’

The truth is that generosity cannot exist without boundaries. But most of us aren’t comfortable setting them because we care more about what people will think and we don’t want to disappoint anyone. Most of us want everyone to like us. And boundaries aren’t easy, but they’re the key to self-love and sustainability. Certainly, in my work, I regularly see boundaries as the key to financial self-love and sustainability.

Now, if you’re a people pleaser, you won’t love boundaries. To people pleasers, boundaries just get in the way. But for obligers or those of us who grew up in chaotic or abusive homes and learned to survive and/or escape by doing whatever it took, people pleasing without boundaries can negatively affect our financial health.

In her book *Rising Strong*, Brené talks about her own experience as a people pleaser and how this played out in her life:

We do that [deal with discomfort and pain] by numbing the pain with whatever provides the quickest relief. We can take the edge off